are typically less interested in critically examining particular Israeli policies than in questioning the very idea of a Jewish state and its right to a future. Its establishment, they contend, was a "mistake"; its continuation, an act of injustice against the "indigenous" people; and its exclusivist, militaristic character at serious odds with the ethical traditions of Judaism itself. At the ideational core of such "criticism" one finds what the British scholar Bernard Harrison calls a "dialectical scam." It goes something like this: (a) spot an Israeli action that can serve as the ground of "criticism of Israel"—e.g., Israel's military incursion into the area near Jenin in April 2002 in response to Palestinian terrorist massacres; (b) then "dissent" from Israel in the strongest possible terms, for instance, by likening what the dissenters denounced as the Nazi-like "razing of Jenin" to the destruction of the Warsaw Ghetto, (c) when taken to task by more sober-minded observers who find that, contrary to your charge, there was no such thing as "the razing of Jenin" and that the IDF has nothing in common with the SS—cry "foul" and claim their censure perfectly illustrates the point that there really is a Jewish organizational conspiracy to silence "criticism of Israel" by branding the authors of such criticism "antisemites."

For some, this dialectical scam works nicely and validates their sense of themselves as intellectual martyrs suffering for a higher ideological cause. Once one is on to it, however, the scam readily dissolves into what it actually is: an expression of political bias, compounded by a touch of hysteria, masquerading as victimization. Seen in these terms, "criticism of Israel" lacks persuasive arguments and is empty at its core. Nevertheless, it needs to be taken seriously, for in certain circles it has strong appeal and can provoke damaging political action against the Jewish state.

A prominent example is the rapid growth of the BDS (boycott, divest, sanction) campaign on American campuses. At its annual meeting, in December 2013, the American Studies Association passed a resolution in support of boycotting Israeli academic institutions. Previously, two smaller professional groups, the Asian Studies Association and the Native American and Indigenous Studies Association, passed similar resolutions. Discussion of a boycott was also prominently featured at the annual meeting of the Modern Language Association in January 2014. Prior to these actions, several American scholars contributed articles to the AAUP-sponsored *Journal of Academic Freedom*, volume four, presenting grounds for such boycotts. In making their charges against Israel, these resolutions and position papers employ more or less the same language, all of it condemnatory.

Joan Scott, of Princeton's Institute for Advanced Study (and herself a Jew), for instance, claims that "the Israeli state regularly denies academic

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